The numbers corroborate the shift in women's participation in management. The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation's *Women and Men in India 2025: Selected Indicators and Data*, released in April, said the number of women in managerial positions rose 102.54% between 2017 and 2025, compared with a 73.80% increase for men.

What does it take to build a business in a new or fast-changing industry, and what role do women leaders play in helping it grow beyond its early promise? It's not simply about entering male-dominated sectors or occupying senior positions. It is also about building teams, establishing processes, taking difficult decisions and creating organisations that can function at scale.

## THE WORK BEHIND SCALE

When Anjali Sardana decided to build a home-services business in India, she was stepping into unfamiliar territory. Raised in the US, she had limited exposure to the country's informal labour markets and no experience of running operations on the ground. The doubts were obvious, including from her own family. But the founder of Pronto chose to start anyway.

"If you were prepared, you probably wouldn't do it," she tells *Business Today*, reflecting on the leap into a business that seeks to organise the market for household services.

Pronto's proposition extends beyond matching customers with workers. It seeks to formalise a largely informal workforce, create more predictable earning opportunities, improve working conditions, and build systems that can support a much larger operation. She sees India's large workforce as an opportunity to develop capabilities around AI and robotics in the physical world. The challenge is to translate that vision into reliable service delivery, effective worker support and repeatable operations.

Thousands of kilometres away, in Chennai, almost over a decade ago, Rekha Murthy Rangarajan, Whole-time Director at Data Patterns, a vertically integrated defence and aerospace electronics solutions provider, was making a very different bet. In 2002, she left a rewarding corporate career to join Data Patterns, founded by her husband Srinivasagopalan Rangarajan. The business had about 45 employees. Her brief was to build human resource, recruitment, training and administrative functions. Over time, she also took responsibility for processes at the company's manufacturing facility. Today, Data Patterns has a workforce of around 1,700 and has grown from building electronic subsystems to larger systems for defence and aerospace applications, says Rangarajan.

## In the Driver's Seat

**GROWTH IN THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE IN MANAGERIAL POSITIONS, 2017–2025**




**SOURCE** MINISTRY OF STATISTICS AND PROGRAMME IMPLEMENTATION, WOMEN AND MEN IN INDIA 2025

## Building A Robust Business

- **Women are building across emerging industries. From defence and drones to digital platforms and home services, their leadership spans sectors and business functions**
- **It's not just about entering male-dominated sectors or taking senior positions. It is also about building teams, establishing processes, taking difficult decisions**